

primary chip responsible for the functioning of our computers. Mining with this method hogged the resources of the computer. And although a CPU is a good multitasker, it's not the most efficient chip for doing the same task over and over, which is exactly what searching for the golden hash involved.

Theoretically, a better chip for mining is the graphical processing unit (GPU). As its name implies, GPUs are used to generate the graphics that appear on screens, but they are now also widely used for machine learning applications. GPUs are massively parallel processing units, meaning they can run similar calculations in parallel because they have hundreds or thousands of mini-processing units, as opposed to CPUs that have just a handful of processing units.⁴

While the little units within a GPU cannot perform the wide range of abstract operations that a CPU can, they are good enough for hashing together data. Since there are thousands or more of these cores, in aggregate a GPU chip can make many more attempts at the golden hash per second than a CPU chip can.

However, to use GPUs a new version of the Bitcoin software needed to be created that could instruct a GPU how to go about the process, and writing that code took time. It was finally released in the summer of 2010, after Jeff Garzik offered a reward of 10,000 bitcoin to the originators—a mining operation known as puddinpop—to open source the software for all to use.⁵ While he may not have expected the price to rise so much in the coming years, Garzik's donation now totals more than \$10 million.